



time India was represented on that stage since Anand. In last year's World Cup, Arjun faced a tough quarterfinal loss to compatriot Praggnanandhaa, and shortly after, he finished behind Gukesh in the Chennai Grandmasters. Despite these disappointments, each setback became a valuable, if clichéd, learning experience.

"In the World Cup match with Pragg, if I hadn't been so attached to the result, I believe I had a good chance to win. I wouldn't have felt the pressure and could've played better. In the Chennai Grandmasters, I almost gave up hope of tying for first place. But I won the last two rounds and ended up tying, which taught me that my mental approach was working against me, so I consciously worked on this. I had done inner engineering meditation, which has helped me," he explains.

The shift in Arjun's approach has transformed his performances, enabling him to dictate terms in every tournament he enters. "It's not that I perform my best just because the stakes are high. In fact, it was the

opposite. I used to struggle under high-pressure situations. Maybe it had to do with my self-imposed pressure when I desperately wanted something. Now, I've let go of that pressure. Whether it's a high-stakes game or even when there's not much on the line, I still play with consistent high quality. That's been a huge help," he shares.

Arjun's strong foundation in chess has made him adept at shorter time controls as well. The 21-year-old — who received all his three IM norms and as many GM norms in a span of just eight months — admires the versatility of Frenchman Firouzja, whom he finds thrilling to watch, and sees shorter time formats as the future of chess. "Firouzja excels in all three formats, including Bullet. Ideally, every player wants to be skilled across formats, especially since high-stakes classical games can also end up in shorter time controls. Classical chess is still the priority, but with events like the Global Chess League and Championship Chess Tour, there's a shift in focus," he notes.

Gold rush: Arjun Erigaisi's incredible 10/11 performance on Board 3 earned him both individual and team gold for India at the Budapest Chess Olympiad.

MICHAL WALUSZA / FIDE

Today's confident and resilient Arjun can trace much of his growth back to a major setback eight years ago. In 2016, a 12-year-old Arjun, then a Candidate Master, travelled to Moscow to compete in the Aeroflot Open's challenger section, accompanied by his mother. On arrival, he requested the organisers to let him participate in the main event. The experience turned into a tough learning curve as he won only one game in nine rounds, losing close to 30 rating points.

"Losing 25 to 30 points in a tournament isn't unheard of, especially with a K-factor of 20. But scoring just one point in eight rounds is rare, especially since you usually face weaker opponents after initial losses. But that tournament was so strong that even at a 2300 rating, I was the lowest-seeded player. I lost